

music management worth investing time in. Consider a library in which everything is haphazardly arranged! Will you be able to find what you're looking for? Similarly, I'm sure it gets on your nerves when you can't find the song you are looking for. After a few hours of tagging and organising the songs, life can become much easier.

The benefits of a properly-tagged and managed music collection are:

1. Easier and faster search
2. The ability to use advanced music features like album art, cover switcher (in iPods only), etc.
3. Identification of albums and artists

To get started with managing your music, all you need are a few supplementary tools. So here is a guide to editing and managing your music effectively in GNU/Linux.

You will require a few specialised tools and media players:

- EasyTag: An advanced music ID3 tag editor
- Picard: An online music editor from MusicBrainz
- An audio player
 - Banshee 1.4.1 for GNOME users
 - Amarok 2.0/1.4.10 for KDE

Note that you can always select the media player you like; I have chosen Amarok and Banshee because these are the most advanced media players from the Linux barracks. Since Amarok 2 is still under development, you might find some glitches while working with it. The latest version of Amarok requires KDE 4.1.3; so if you have KDE you should consider updating your DE first. Additionally, Mandriva KDE users might face some problems playing a few audio files with Amarok because Mandriva 2009 KDE includes *phonon-gstreamer*. To pass this problem, first install *phonon-xine* and then remove *phonon-gstreamer*.

Installing and adding software

Installing the software is perhaps the easiest part. You can install all the above-mentioned software using your distro's default package manager, considering that all the major distros have the latest stable packages in their repositories.

If there is no package available for your distro, you can always download the source code from the project site [see *Resources* section] and compile it. You can also take the help of the following websites to locate a binary package for your distribution:

- rpmfind.net: A one-stop shop for RPM users, which lists RPM packages provided by most of the RPM-based distros.
- getdeb.net: This website not only provides easy access to deb packages for Debian-based distros, but also gives quite a lot of information about the software you are downloading.

Note that users of Ubuntu Hardy Heron (8.04 LTS) or earlier versions will not find Banshee 1 in their default repositories. In order to get the latest version of Banshee, either install from the source code or add Banshee PPA



Figure 1: 'Now Playing' in Banshee



Figure 2: The default interface of Amarok 2 RC1



Figure 3: Banshee, showing the added albums

repositories—this gets you the latest stable packages of Banshee. To add this repository, click on the **System** menu on the GNOME panel, navigate to **Administration**→**Software Source**, and add the repositories listed in edge.launchpad.net/~banshee-team/+archive

Mandriva users need to enable the **testing** repositories. Navigate to **Mandriva Control Centre**→**Configure Media** and enable it.